Secretary to 'send for Doctor Lo (the Ambassador of Nationalist China in New Delhi). Tell him of our decision. Tell him also that it is with deep regret that we have to sever our official relations with him.' [27]

The cutting off of ties with the Nationalist government in Taiwan was inevitable, but it should have been part of the give-and-take during the negotiations. Instead, India squandered a bargaining point as a concession to Communist China even before the negotiations commenced. Likewise, India made efforts to reassure the Chinese side that it would not harm them by aligning with the Americans. This meant that India gave up any leverage that was to be gained by allowing the Chinese side to believe that it had the option of leaning to the side of the Americans in case China did not accommodate its interests in the process of diplomatic recognition. Thus, India lost another tactical advantage that might have allowed it to extract assurances from the Chinese Communists.

Thirdly, and most significantly, India did not lay out substantive 'asks' for the Chinese side to fulfil as a counter-response to their demands, even though they were aware of Chinese preconditions. The Government of India felt that making recognition dependent upon fulfilment of conditions by the new Chinese regime may be seen as hard or humiliating. Instead, Zhou Enlai's oral assurance to Panikkar over a dinner at the end of September 1949 that Indian interests in Tibet would be protected was considered an adequate enough guarantee to secure India's interests. The lament by the Indian Political Officer in Gangtok to the Secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs on 20 October 1949—'when the time comes to recognize the Communist government it should be stated in general terms that such recognition is without prejudice to existing rights and commitments of the Government of India; but the